

The Play Plan with Trumps

The opponents can ruff too. The plan decides when to draw trumps, when to wait, what comes first.



1 On defense: leading against a trump contract

Quick tricks

A long suit helps little: declarer will ruff it. **Two touching honors** are enough to lead from a sequence.

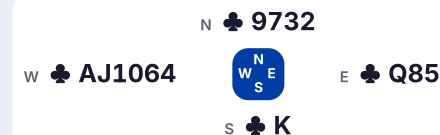
♠ KQ7 ♥ 62 ♦ J9732 ♣ A72
against 4♥: the K♠, better than the 2♦.

Looking for a ruff

Lead a short suit to get a ruff. From two cards, **always the higher**: from 74 the 7, from 102 the 10, from A9 the ace.

♠ 2 ♥ A62 ♦ J982 ♣ Q8752
against 4♥: the 2♠.

Never underlead an ace



Against 4♥ the J♣ lets South's singleton king win, and the ace never scores.

2 Declarer: draw trumps?

With long side-suit winners or establishable cards, draw trumps: otherwise they'll get ruffed.

N ♥ K54
S ♥ A2
5 cards: a ruff is very unlikely

N ♥ K732
S ♥ A4
6 cards: still a low risk

N ♥ KQJ3
S ♥ A42
7 cards: the third round survives under 50%

N ♥ 732
S ♥ KQJ104
after losing the ace: maybe one trick, not two

Spades are trumps, hearts are the side suit: the more cards your side holds, the likelier an honor gets ruffed.

3 Only short winners? Ruff

NORTH ♠ AK8 ♥ A743 ♦ 732 ♣ J92
SOUTH ♠ 6532 ♥ 8 ♦ AK854 ♣ 853
2♦ · West leads the Q♥

You need 8 tricks; the side suits give 3. Drawing trumps, diamonds take 4, never 5. So: A♥, heart ruffed with the 4; spade to the ace, heart ruffed with the 5; spade to the king, heart ruffed with the 8. Hearts 4-4: **8 tricks**.

4 Wait to draw trumps

NORTH ♠ 82 ♥ 83 ♦ A92 ♣ Q97543
SOUTH ♠ AKQJ95 ♥ A92 ♦ 873 ♣ A
4♠ · West leads the 2♣

9 tricks, and drawing trumps leaves 9. At once **A♥ and a heart**; later a heart ruffed in dummy: **10 tricks**. Even one round of trumps would be fatal: on lead with a heart, a defender plays a trump and the ruff is gone.

Wait to draw trumps if you need ruffs in the short hand.

5 Setting up a ruff

N ♠ xxx ♥ 32
S ♠ AKQ32 ♥ A74

A♥ and a heart, then a heart ruffed in dummy.

N ♠ xxxx ♥ 85
S ♠ AKQ64 ♥ 932

Duck a heart twice: then ruff the third.

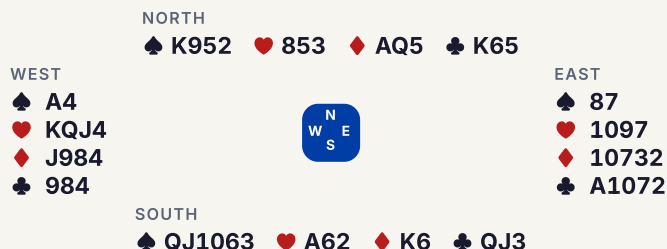
N ♠ xxx ♥ K6
S ♠ AKQ32 ♥ Q52

K♥, lose to the ace, cash the queen and ruff.

N ♠ xx ♥ K7
S ♠ AKQ743 ♥ A53

K♥, A♥, then a heart ruff.

6 Urgent things first



4♠, West leads the K♥. Win and draw trumps, and the defense takes two hearts, the A♠ and the A♣: down one. Instead, after the A♥, South cashes K♦, Q♦, A♦ discarding a heart: the third heart can now be ruffed.

When your plan gives up the lead, always ask what the opponents will do next.